

SYMPATHY, SAINTS, HERBS, AND HUMORS

magic and medicine

▼ Medical divination

Here, the caladrius bird, a fabled snow-white waterfowl that frequented royal courts, is used for divination—if it looked away from a patient, he would die; if it stared in his direction, the sick person would recover and the bird would fly away, miraculously carrying off the illness.

Medieval medicine was a diverse field, in which magic vied with science as physicians developed more sophisticated surgical procedures and used a wider range of herbal remedies. As knowledge of medicine grew and methods became more professional, practices previously relegated to quacks and local healers became more respectable.

Christian writers, such as St. Augustine in the 4th–5th centuries, had long viewed disease as a divine punishment for sin, which, equally, was subject to God's grace in its cure. Augustine condemned medical divination and practices such as hanging curative amulets on patients to signify demonic possession.

